KnOs PRODUCTION & HELIKOS PRESENT

THE DEPRESSED CLOWN

A Mental Show of Laughter and Tears...

Script	KNUT OSTRADAL
	GIOVANNI FUSETTI
Director	GIOVANNI FUSETTI
Scenography	GABRIELA MELO LARSEN
Puppets	TATJANA ZAITZOW
Actor	KNUT OSTRADAL
Puppeteer	GIOVANNI FUSETTI

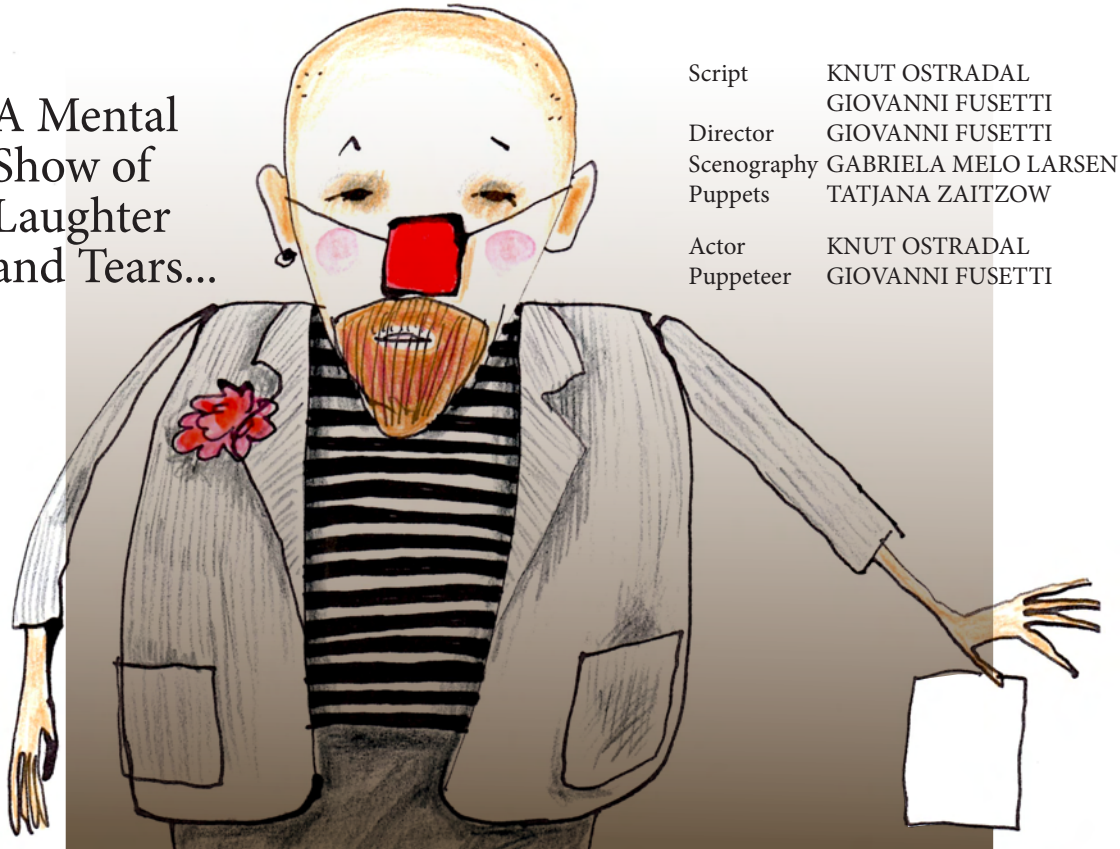


Illustration: Tatjana Zaitzow

Yesterday is history

Tomorrow is a mystery

Today is a gift –

That is why we call it the Present

DIRECTOR'S NOTES

The Depressed Clown is based on the story of the author, Knut Ostradal, who in a period of his life found himself in the mysterious land of depression. Knut emerged from this journey with the need of the storyteller to share with the world what he found in these uncomfortable depths. This is the third version of Knut's story. In the first production (Depression, the Musical), in Norwegian, presented in 2018 with the direction of Kristian Landmark and Giert Werring as puppeteer, Knut was telling his story as himself, with a series of puppets in supporting roles. In 2020 I stepped into the role of Director for the English version of the play. In this new incarnation, it is the clown Theobald who tells the story of his journey into depression and back, and the puppets are

now a chorus of characters holding the space of the story with him. In parallel with the translation from Norwegian to English, my work as a director has been to turn a story that was previously told as a past event, into something happening in front of your eyes, in the here and now of a Clown's life. The presence of the puppets has grown and so has their integration with Theobald's story. The vocal creativity of Christer Wold Sundstol as a puppeteer and a singer has allowed the show to explore further the edge between text and songs, between rhythm and music. Now, in 2026, in this third reiteration, in the curious dance of life, I step into the show as the puppeteer returning to a theatre form that was my very first performing experience more than thirty years ago. What a treat! The Red Nose Clown and the Puppets are both theatres masks, essentialized and transposed forms of humanity. Their language emerges from the body: feelings, urgencies and emotional states become gestures and sounds and, eventually, words and songs. The Clown and the puppets have guided us in our quest for humour in a story of darkness. They have helped us to explore these questions: Is there music in the land of depression? Can we sing while we are drowning in sadness? Can we laugh at the edge of the abyss? Or at least smile? We are delighted to share our exploration with you.

Giovanni Fusetti



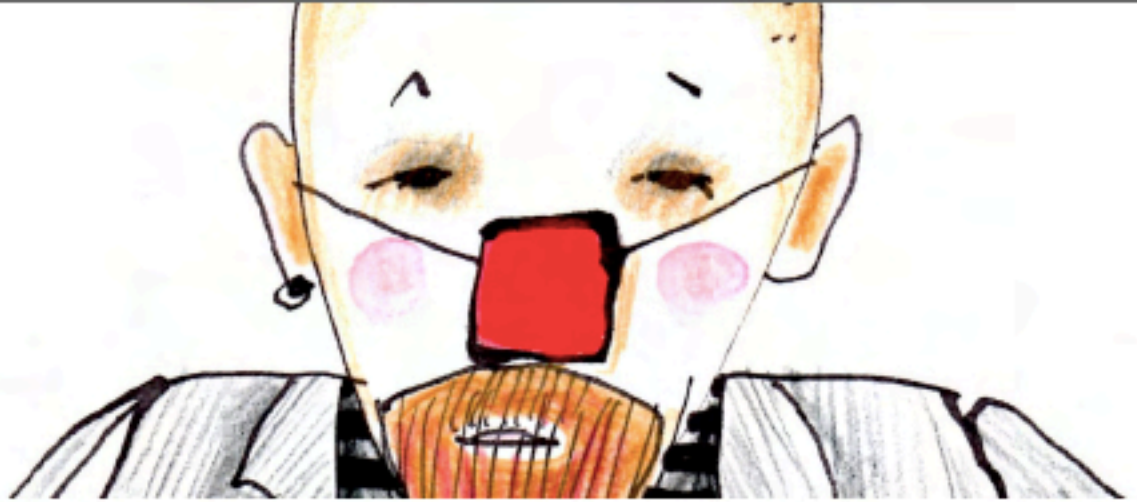
Dear Audience

This performance is about depression – the state of lacking energy and appetite that occurs when the brain doesn't produce enough serotonin and dopamine for a person to function as they wish.

The story that is told is based on my own experiences in the deepest darkness of depression – and although there are many paths into depression, the symptoms that characterise it are quite similar.

There are not many people without past or present contact with depression, either self-experienced or with a person close to you or farther away.

Mental health is still a topic that many find difficult to talk about in public. There is a so-called stigma associated with being mentally ill in one form or another. It is easier to show up with a plastered leg and be able to state that in eight weeks or so the crutches can be thrown away and life may continue as before.



The main purpose of our performance is to show that it is possible to leave the darkness for the light and rediscover the meaning and content of life.

The feeling of being born again is strongly present – without any guarantee that the condition will continue indefinitely. I felt like I was eating life with a tiny teaspoon – now it's like eating it with a big ladle.

To you who are struggling – do not give up! There is hope for light at the end of the tunnel even though it may never have looked as dark as right now.

I would like to take the opportunity to thank my therapist Karl Erik Karlsen and the attending staff who have taken care of me during my illness. I would also like to thank my wonderful production team who have been so dedicated and made all their artistic and human resources available.

The title of the show is paradox: The Depressed Clown. It is a kind of invitation to seriousness as well as entertainment. I have chosen a clown as a character to tell the story. The clown exists at the intersection of tragedy and comedy – with his characteristic face made up with black lines under his eyes symbolizing tears and a big smiling mouth. A serious topic becomes the subject of ridicule – some elements are absurd and filled with the comedy of everyday life.

It is not at all our intention to downplay a serious condition by using comedy. It is rather our conviction that a liberating laugh may open the way for conversations that can be of help to those caught in the glaring claws of darkness

Knut Ostradal



KNUT ØSTRÅDAL is a 1947 model, and a happy Jubilado/ pensioner living in Barcelona and Kristiansand. He worked for almost 40 years as a high school teacher at Kristiansand Cathedral School where he taught drama, French, English and film as an elective subject. After majoring in drama/theatre, he went to Paris and the *Ecole Internationale de Théatre Jacques Lecoq* – and theater has been a hobby and a profession since childhood. He has been active in amateur theatre, professional theatre and film in a number of projects and productions. In 1979 he co-founded *Fabelteatret* , which created a number of revues with flair and sting in the 1980s.



TATJANA ZAITZOW graduated from NTH in 1966. She has experience as architect, dancer and craftsperson. In 1978 she established *Petrusjka Teater* where she was artistic director, set designer, playwright, character actor and project manager for 30 years. Petrusjka Teater has participated in the Puppet Theatre Festival in Kristiansand for several years, and received the Tyrihans Prize in 1997. Tatjana has also participated as a puppeteer in Agder Teater's "Dustefjerten and the big marzipan party". She has toured in large parts of Europe, in Russia and in Canada. Now she is retired but still active as a character developer for other theatres



GABRIELA MELO LARSEN is a set designer, costume designer, and visual artist from Brazil, living in Kristiansand. She works as a set designer at Kilden Teater as well as a freelance artist. Larsen is also the initiator and leader of *Stemmene Kunstverksted*, and her works explore the intersection of performing arts and visual arts.

FRODE HOLGERSEN works in the yellow building – almost sunny, almost a summer house. He made his debut as a set designer at Rosegården – after actually drawing a set sketch on a napkin at Vågsbygd Center. The play in question was Big fuss over nothing, staged by Athene Teater. "I called myself a sculptor when I got a job as a theatre painter at Kilden Teater. Alf Gunnar Huseth tricked me into becoming a theatre painter – eternally grateful."

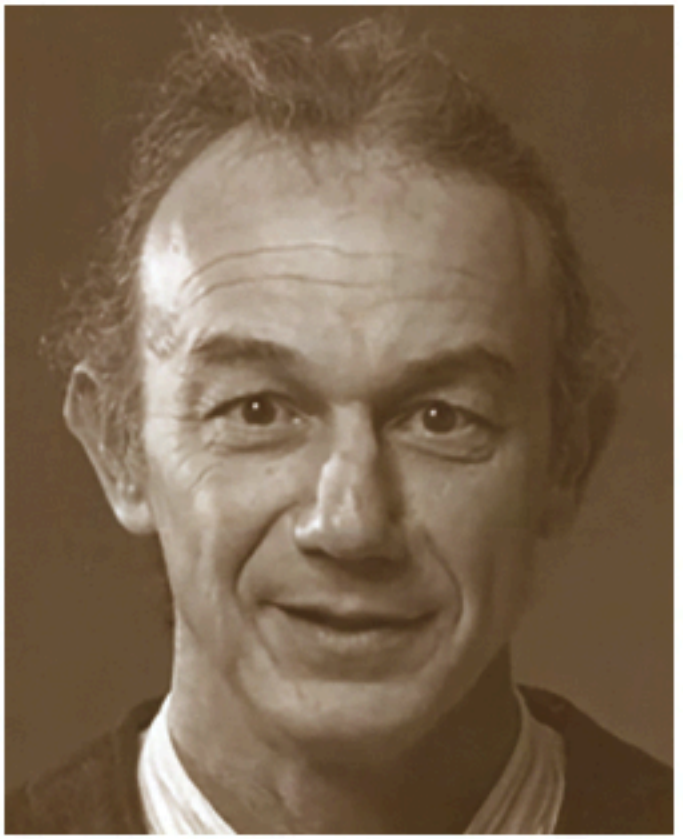


GIERT WERRING (1950), puppeteer and senior lecturer (did his first puppetry things in the Catholic Church in the early sixties). And from the early seventies he has kept the *Baldrian & Musa Puppet Theatre* going. At the beginning of the 1990s, Werring was employed at Agder Teater as a puppeteer, as well as manager and life supporter for the International Figure Theatre Festival. At the same time, he was employed at UiA, eventually as senior lecturer (drama). For the last 18 years, he has also been hired by Kristiansand Zoo, especially engaged with the fictional universe created by Torbjørn Egner.



HARALD STENSLAND has handled the touring activities of *KOLON theatre* all over Norway for 27 years. Harald calls himself a cultural entrepreneur through his involvement in various cultural expressions: at the youth culture festival UKM, in local feature films, and as a light and sound lecturer, as well as his roles in coastal culture lectures and TV productions in the Forskergrandprix. But deep down he is trained as a low-voltage electrician and in computer science (!).





GIOVANNI FUSETTI

is an Italian multi-disciplinary fool. He trained at the *Ecole International de Théâtre Jacques Lecoq* in Paris where he was also pedagogic assistant and then teacher of improvisation. He is the founding pedagogic director of *HELIKOS, International School of Theatre Creation*, based in Padova, Italy. Giovanni works internationally as a pedagogue, teacher, director, devising consultant and process facilitator, exploring theatre in performance, artistic training, education, therapy and political action. He is passionate about midwifing clowns, buffoons and masks. In his pedagogy, he integrates physical theatre with different practices of physical and emotional awareness, for the training of the actor/poet/creator. His 35 years of pedagogical research include training in Theatre in Education, Augusto Boal's Theatre of the Oppressed, Gestalt Therapy, Reichien Analysis and Process Work. You can find more details at: *https://giovannifusetti.com*.

ROBERTA BIANCHINI

The Red Noses are designed and handmade in leather by Roberta Bianchini, Maskmaker, Italy

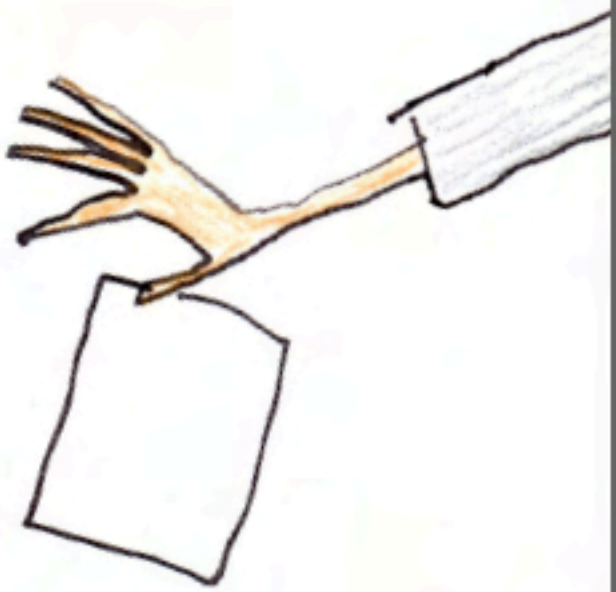
Roberta Bianchini

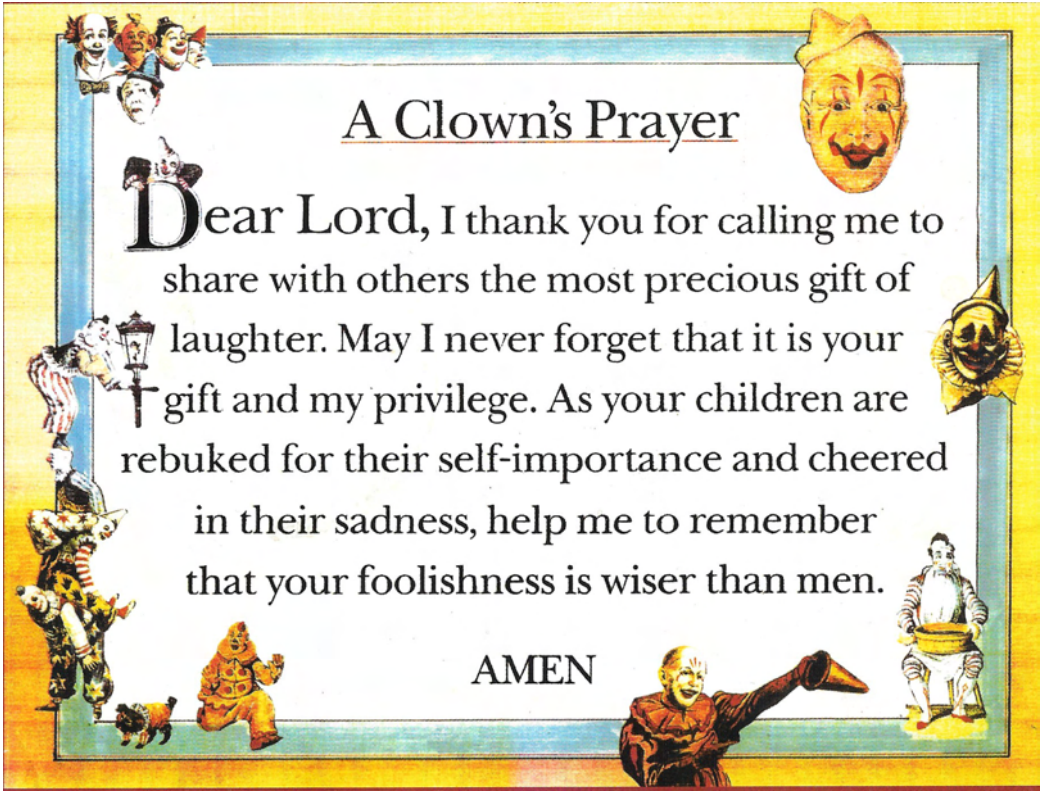
https://ro-bianchini.wixsite.com/roberta-bianchini

DEPRESSION…
Is a mental illness
Marked by a thoroughly low state of mind
Combined with low self esteem
And loss of interest in activities
That normally give pleasure

A special credit to Erik Pirolt, who created the scenography for the first version, and **Christer Sundstøl** for his vocal creativity in the second version.

A deeply felt gratitude to my friends: Ingrid (who kept the lamp), Tori (for the angels), Emil Otto (who pushed) Karl Erik Karlsen (my therapist), who all cared; my family Erik, Elin, Maja, Camilla; Anne-Karen, Mette, Evelyn, Colleen, Josefine, Rune B for giving comfort in the darkness; Victoria Millard for text inspiration; Roberta for the excellent red noses ... and to the many others who cared and helped me back into the light. Thank you to Jørn for the layout of the programme and the poster, to Annabelle for her excellent translation – and to Tatjana Zaitzow for the wonderful puppets, and drawings to the poster and the programme. Also, a special thank you to Kristian and Giert for their wonderful work in the birthing of the first version of the show.





This prayer is used every year at the annual Clowns International Service, on the first Sunday in February at the Holy Trinity Church, known as The Clowns' Church, in Dalston, London.

Funding:

NORSK KULTURFOND

KRISTIANSAND KOMMUNE

AGDER FYLKESKOMMUNE

CULTIVA